SAFI'S GUIDE TO MALTA

SHORT STORY

URSULA WEST

CHAPTER 1

Munro must have travelled at least three feet before collapsing in a tired heap. The kiosk was ten yards away, but it was impossible for him to move any further.

"So you still think you can do it on your own?" Safi said.

"I can, I can," croaked Munro. "and I don't need any of your interspatial hyperlinks. I'm human - I can do it!"

It was just as well that no one else but Munro could see Safi. He towered above his human friend like a giant umbrella, his orange hat extending well past Munro's body. But it still didn't seem to shelter him from the scorching sun.

Safi handed him a crumpled bus ticket.

"I can't bear to watch any more. Take this, you idiot. There's no need to win this bet. You don't really think I would have paid you, anyway?"

Munro sat up and glared at Safi.

"I'll never know that now, will I?"

"No, but then you don't know much, anyway. Like, what is life, when is an atom not an atom, what is Mangodanga or

when is it? You know what your problem is, don't you Munro? You're such an easy target!"

Alien or not, this practical joker seemed to win each round.

It had all started so simply, but ever since meeting Safi at the Carnival, life had changed.

To begin with, Munro had thought Safi was just another reveler in fancy dress, but he soon realized his mistake.

Safi had a way of pointing out his mistakes.

In one short afternoon, Safi had introduced Munro to the concept of inter-dimensional existence. That life was not all it seemed to be. That his life in his adopted country of Malta, a sunny island in the Med, held more secrets than he would ever know and that he, Munro, was being invited to discover them.

A bus ticket, for example, wasn't just for buses. No, Safi and his like had somehow manoeuvred the numbering sequence to encapsulate neat little codes that were keys to other kinds of journeys.

His present state was a typical example. Bus ticket S.38 041385 was the exact formula for body molecular change/3B104 (i.e. - it made him heavier than lead). This, of course, only happened at three thirty on a Wednesday afternoon and only when sitting behind one fat lady and a thin man on a 62 bus.

As luck would have it, he was.

Munro had read the number three times in quick succession, as Safi had instructed, and the change had taken place as soon as he stepped off the bus.

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"YOU'RE LUCKY," Safi chirped in, "you could have got ticket S.38 041387 and sat beside a blonde girl."

"WHAT WOULD HAVE HAPPENED THEN?"

"You would have found yourself in Viegela"

"So?"

"You don't want to go there, believe me. At least not unless you are a jelly based Lancoped."

"Yes, well, how do I get back to normal? I've had enough of this one."

"RECITE the number again and say 'stop' between every word. S stop 3 stop 8 stop 0 stop and so on."

Munro did it and, at the last 'stop', he popped back into the real world, at which point, someone tripped over him on the pavement.

YES, he was back!

OVER THE NEXT TWO MONTHS, Safi had become a regular visitor. His visits were occurring at least once a week. Mostly, it was good fun and in some ways, he was beginning to see Safi as a sort of friend. At least, in an odd kind of way.

In fact, he hadn't seen him for at least 10 days now, but he knew he was about to show up. Something extremely strange had happened and Munro knew, without a doubt, that Safi was behind it. He stood there, waiting for the 'joker' to show his face.

Nothing was moving; or making any noise. The world and all life around him had 'frozen' and he was the only thing

still living and breathing normally. The room and everything else had stopped, just like a frozen frame on a video.

MUNRO WALKED IN BETWEEN THE 'FROZEN' people. It was like moving through a screen at the cinema while the projectionist had gone for a coffee break and left the machinery on pause. Any minute now, he thought, the 'film' would start up again and it would carry on where it had left off.

HE SIGHED. It didn't look like that was going to happen.

As he looked around the office, Munro calmly took in the odd scene. Matthew, the wages clerk, was leaning out of the window, his cigarette an inch from his lips and a slow, satisfying drag. A faint wisp of smoke from its tip curled upwards and hung, immovable, in midair.

THE TYPIST'S finger had just struck the letter 's', but the computer had not yet displayed the character on the screen.

"IT WAS HER FAULT!" said a voice behind him.

MUNRO WHIRLED round to see the figure of Safi standing behind him.

"She typed the 'STOP' command," said Safi.

"I knew it! I knew it was you!" shouted Munro. "Put all this back to normal right now. This is going too far!"

"What do you mean, old friend?"

"I'm not your old friend and you know exactly what I

mean. It's one thing getting me into weird situations - but not the entire WORLD! Get them back!"

"But I can't Munro. She did it. She typed the stop command."

"What stop command? She was just typing."

"Ah yes, but she blew her nose three times before and hesitated 9.5 tenths of a second between the 'a' and the 's'; which is the exact formula on Wednesday the 10th at this latitude and at a temperature of 24.5 degrees centigrade."

"Rubbish!" snapped Munro. "You make these things up so you can do just what you feel like."

"Not so, not so, Munro. I can assure you, this is really happening." He peered steadily into Munro's eyes and an awkward silence created space between them. He backed away and flicked the rim of his hat, pretending to brush away some imaginary dust. His tall figure sauntered around the room, hardly looking at the frozen scene.

"The truth is," he whispered, "these things happen all the time," The silence continued for a while.

"Is that a fact?" said Munro, not bothering to look at Safi. "Strange, I don't remember when the world stopped the last time. I must have missed it!"

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SAFI LET OUT a little moan and snapped back into full voice. "All right then, I suppose I will just have to explain everything to you."

He sat on the edge of a desk and swung one long leg over the other in a rather elegant and deliberate manner.

"You never saw it happen before because you, Munro Spencer, are now my chosen URL. Before this, you were not in the EEE. Now that you are, now that I have officially registered you, you can see exactly what happens."

Munro was silent. Safi was silent.

"There," said Safi, "Now you know,"

"The EEE?" said Munro, his voice reduced to an exasperated squeak. "What on Earth are you talking about?"

"THE 'ENTITY EXISTENCE ENCYCLOPEDIA' - and since, by my request, you are now a registered member, a registered URL, you can now see what's really going on."

Munro decided it was no use badgering this being. He would use reason, tact and gentle persuasion to extract something that made sense.

"WHAT THE HELL ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT!" he shouted.

MUNRO WAS STANDING STOCK STILL, his arms at his side and his clenched fists white at the knuckles.

"Marvellous, just great ... everything's stopped except me. It's a nightmare! I'm stuck in a bad dream with a crazy person, saying crazy things." This was all a step too far.

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SAFI WAS quiet for a few minutes as he rubbed his long fingers around his chin. "You know, Munro, perhaps you need some more explanation. Look, I will give you an example from your own world."

He got up and walked round to the computer on Munro's desk. "You have something you call the INTERNET." He intoned the word with an accent that made it sound alien.

"THE INTERNET IS like a flat copy of something that runs the Universe. Do you know how you have names for places you want to go to? You call them URLs, Uniform Resource Locators. They take you to where you want to go. Well, we use URL's too; they are Universal REALITY Locators. They take us to where we want to go as well. Everything has a place, a number, a relation to everything else. We register them, and then we use them to link to other things and so on and so on."

MUNRO LISTENED IN SILENCE. He now understood, but he didn't like what he was hearing.

"You mean you are using me, like a page on the internet!"

"COME ON, DEAR FELLOW," said Safi, striding towards him. "It's not that bad. For one, it is an excellent chance to see behind the scenes."

"Really!," said Munro, folding his arms tightly in front of him. "I'd like you to show me the fun in this."

"WELL, for a start, you get to start time up again," said Safi.

"I do, do I? - So where's the button? Show me. Give me a

crazy number to say back to front. What do I do this time? Stand on my head and poke my finger in my ear?"

"Before I selected you," said Safi, still trying to explain, "these things happened all around you, every day."

Munro opened his mouth to give a snappy answer.

Safi held up a hand. "Silence now. There's a good chap."

Munro paused.

"They were adjusted, corrected, directed and guided without you, or anyone else, knowing about it."

"Really!" said Munro.

"Shush, now listen!"

Munro peered at Safi. "You're not God, mate. You don't even come close."

"No, but everybody has to do their part, you know. I suggest that you don't get philosophical with me Munro, you're not in the same league."

Somehow, Munro believed him.

"Let's drop this Safi. Let's just get things back to normal."

Safi smiled. Munro was indeed a decent chap.

"All right, here's what we do; no, what you do. You need to decide what you want to change. What you see around you now, is not a brittle picture, it's a real 'snapshot' of a millisecond. The atoms of that second are 'frozen' in time. You, yourself, can't move or destroy anything. You tell me what you want to change, and I'll arrange the atoms accordingly."

"Then what?" asked Munro.

"Then time, space and this reality will continue again from that new point - that's all there is to it."

"So if I move that pencil from there to there," said Munro, "it all goes back to normal."

"Hopefully, yes."

"Hopefully?"

"Well, whatever change you make will be re-ordered both backwards and forwards and that might have one or two consequences; some changes that you might notice. And, in this case, a pencil moving is not sufficient; it needs a bigger kick-start than that, say a town or a bit of countryside."

MUNRO STARED IN HORROR. Safi took him by the arm and guided him out of the office while he was still in his stunned silence.

"Come, I'll take you on a flight and we can look around before you decide."

THEY WERE SITTING in a sort of clear bubble, floating over the countryside. The ancient city of Mdina looked even more silent than usual. Its walled ramparts and stone streets sprawled over the commanding hilltop, looking down on even more peaceful fields.

"You wouldn't care to move the old lady nearer to the sea, would you?" said Safi.

"Mdina!" exclaimed Munro "you're joking!"

"Yes, I am. That really would put a dent in the history books!"

"Not to mention MY future." said Munro; for once in agreement.

"Well .... yes, I don't think my imagination is up to that." said Safi. It seemed he was actually affected by something for a change. He gave an involuntary shudder and shook his head as if to clear away unwanted thoughts.

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"RIGHT," he said, "What's it to be? Decide Munro. Decide!"

"I can't, I just can't. What do you suggest?"

"Sorry," said Safi, it's against the rules, but maybe I can give you a clue or two."

"O.K. What?"

"Vegetation hasn't much history and is quite substantial; not just a few blades of grass, something a bit more solid, perhaps."

"A tree!" said Munro.

Safi smiled. "I'm not saying anything."

"Right, I've got it. Go to my house, over that way. Land in the garden."

WITHIN A MINUTE or two they were at Munro's house and Munro was scrambling out of the strange craft and dashing around his small garden, giggling and mumbling to himself.

"WOW! what a great break! Come here quick Safi. You are going to do me a big favour."

"Yes?"

"Yes, yes, yes .... for a change you are going to come in really handy," said Munro.

"This is most intriguing," said Safi as he strolled towards him.

[Image: The Tree.png]

"I want the tree at the end of the street to be in that corner of my garden," said Munro triumphantly.

"Mmmm," said Safi. "Are you sure you want that particular tree .... I mean, not one growing in the middle of a field or something?"

"No, Safi. You said you wouldn't interfere. I want that one. It's the bane of my life. It causes so many holdups in

traffic for one reason or another. I've never understood why it's there. They left it like a traffic island right in the middle and made the traffic go round it. I've decided. That's it!"

"As you wish," said Safi. "Come, I'll take you back to your office first."

THE JOURNEY back to Munro's office was quick, but Safi was unusually silent. Munro felt a little uneasy. What was wrong with that decision? Did Safi know something? It was only the bother of trying to choose something else that kept him from changing his mind. "That's it. That's it!" He kept assuring himself. "He'd look just the same, no matter what I chose."

"SEE YOU LATER," said Safi and was gone.

A FEW SECONDS LATER, he appeared again. "Its done. Just stay here and don't move till it's all over. "See you later," he said, and disappeared.

MUNRO WAITED NERVOUSLY, but nothing seemed to happen. He was about to go over and look out of the window, but remembered Safi's warning not to move.

IT WAS hard to tell at first when things happened, because the changes were so imperceptible. It wasn't long, however, before the pace increased.

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THE PENCIL on the table rolled over and fell onto the floor. The wastepaper basket disappeared. A pile of paper on his desk shifted and new files appeared beside them. Matthew's cigarette disappeared and his shirt changed from white to blue striped. Munro found it very amusing.

"One tree ... amazing!" he whispered, hardly daring to disturb the action.

IT WAS NOT until the tall young man materialized near the door that he got butterflies. Something about him looked familiar. A growing unease led to a realization that this person represented a threat.

ANNA'S HAIR rearranged itself and a pair of glasses appeared on his desk before an explosion of sound and movement catapulted him out of his lonely thoughts and into a noisy, stirring world once again.

TIME HAD RETURNED.

THE YOUNG MAN jumped and nearly dropped the papers he was holding.

"Wow! Where did you come from?" He asked.

Anna stopped typing and turned around.

Matthew blinked and dropped his cigarette out of the window. "Sorry Ed, I didn't see him come in," he said.

"Excuse me," said Ed, the tall young man, "for a moment I thought you had just appeared from nowhere!" He went over and picked up the glasses from Munro's desk. "It must be eye strain."

Ed laid a bundle of papers on Munro's desk. "Can I help you?" he said politely.

MUNRO FUMBLED FOR WORDS. He turned to the typist for support.

"Anna, can you just fill me in on the situation? What were we working on?"

"Working on? I'm sorry, I think you have the wrong office." She smiled and stood up, offering some polite help. "This is the wages office. Are you sure you don't mean Anna Micallef downstairs in sales?"

"Yes, yes," stammered Munro, eager to find any excuse to get out.

AS HE WALKED OUT, he tried to make a grab for his jacket, but the coat stand was empty. Munro awkwardly pretended to scratch his head and beat a hasty retreat.

HE MADE it safely out of the front door. Outside, things looked fairly normal, but how would he know? He had known none of these passers-by before. Were they different?

BUT HE REMEMBERED the buses weren't sky blue, and it now appeared that bright Lime Green was this year's fashion colour. He couldn't wait to get home and see the tree in his garden that had caused all this.

"SO YOU'RE HERE," Munro said as he saw Safi waiting for him at the corner of the street. Safi was looking distinctly myste-

rious. "What's wrong?" said Munro.

"Not much," said Safi. "it worked out better than I had calculated, thankfully."

"Really," said Munro "apart from the fact that I seemed to have lost my job and Malta has gone colour crazy?"

"Oh... and one or two other things." said Safi.

"Like What?"

"Well, for one, the tree has been moved and there is now no traffic hazard. Are you pleased?"

"And What else Safi? WHAT ELSE!"

"One or two other things."

"Do you tell me, or do I get to go mad slowly?"

Safi held out a bunch of keys. "You'll need these. You left them in your jacket."

"Yeh, where did that get to?" Munro snatched the keys from Safi's hand but they looked strange, very unfamiliar. He turned them around, trying to figure things out and glanced back at Safi. "Looks like this has changed." He shook his head and let out a sigh.

"Ok, all I want to do is to get home and get on with life. My house is still there, I hope."

Safi smiled sweetly and took a deep breath.

"You don't live there anymore." said Safi.

Munro didn't have to say anything. Safi continued speedily with an explanation.

"Right, now, one or two facts; listen, because I don't care to go through 50,000 years of history; just the bits that matter to you."

He took another deep breath and trundled out the explanation. "The tree came from a seed that was dropped from a bird that flew through a branch from a tree in Rabat. To drop it in that exact place, the bird had to land several meters further on. This caused widespread geographical changes owning to the cat that caught that bird. The present owner of

the house always had the tree in his garden. Loved it, lived a happy life, was a good father, had more children; he's still living there now with his daughter and six grandchildren." Ed, the young man at your office, had an interview for the same post you got five years ago. Instead of being stuck in a traffic jam caused by that tree at the corner of your street, he got there in plenty of time. He was less flustered, and he got the job. You didn't."

"That's how I knew him!" said Munro. "I saw his photo on an application form when I was clearing out some old files. So what am I doing now? Where do I live?"

"You got fed up looking for jobs, took a risk and started the advertising business you had always wanted and now have a plush office in Valletta. Oh, by the way, that's where your jacket is."

Safi hardly stopped for breath. "There's your car; I brought it here. You have the keys, and I'm off."

"Hey, wait a minute, wait a minute! How do I know where I'm going? How will I do my work? Who are my client's, my staff? I know nothing." said Munro.

"You will ... in, say, 30, 35 minutes. It will all seem to come back to you. Well, nearly everything, it will take time."

"And the wages office?"

"Oh yes, you'll remember that too, everything. You have sort of gained five years' experience in one day," Safi allowed himself a wide grin "And of course a lot of money!"

In the comfort of his new office, Munro felt strangely at peace.

The phone rang, and he deftly flicked it to his ear.

"Munro Associates."

"Munro? Where did you get to this morning?"

Munro took his feet off the desk and straightened up.

"Hi," he replied.

"Munro? Is that you? Are you alright? I waited for you - what is this big surprise?"

Munro's mind was a blank mess. "I'm sorry I ...."

"Are you sure you are all right?" There was a moment of silence, and then the soft, warm voice continued. "I'm waiting. Munro. Come on, what's keeping you?" She laughed. "Whatever it is, I forgive you. There! now tell me."

For once, he was lost for words and the silence was deafening. Munro's tie suddenly seemed way too tight. How long did Safi say his memory would take to catch up?

"Munro Wilson!" came the voice again, far more strident. "What's got into you? Is there something wrong?"

He was desperately trying to think of a safe answer, but the pause was a big mistake.

"Munro, I'm coming right over there! There's something weird. I'm coming!"

The phone went dead.

Munro shot out of his chair. He grabbed his jacket from the coat stand beside the door.

"I'm not here!" he shouted to his secretary on the way past. "And remember, I haven't been here all day!"

"Yes Sir," said Madeleine and went on typing.

"But Mr. Wilson," she called after him, "what will I tell your wife? She called me to say she's on the way.